

The Ethiopian Coffee Buyer's Checklist

39 questions to put to any Ethiopian exporter or agent before you commit to an order, for importers, roasters, distributors and hospitality buyers.

Most problems in an international coffee purchase trace back to a question nobody asked at the start. Work through this list with every supplier and keep the answers on file. This is general buying guidance; exact answers always depend on the coffee, the exporter and the shipment.

01 The seller

- ☐ **Exporter's full legal name** and who will sign your sales contract.
- ☐ **Export licence** held by the exporter (Ethiopian coffee exports are regulated by the Ethiopian Coffee and Tea Authority).
- ☐ **Who invoices you** and in which currency.
- ☐ **If an agent is involved:** whom they represent, how they are paid, and what stays with the exporter.
- ☐ **References or past shipments** to your region, if available.

02 The coffee

- ☐ **Region** and, where known, zone, district or locality.
- ☐ **Washing station, cooperative or producer** and the level of traceability offered.
- ☐ **Process** (washed, natural or other).
- ☐ **Export grade** (for example Grade 1 or 2) and what it was based on.
- ☐ **Crop year** and processing date.
- ☐ **Lot reference** that will appear on samples, contract and shipping documents.
- ☐ **Variety information**, if known.

03 Quality evidence

- ☐ **Cupping notes and score** with who evaluated, when, and under which protocol.
- ☐ **Moisture content** (ICO guidance for exported green coffee: 8–12.5%).
- ☐ **Water activity, screen size** and **defect count**.
- ☐ **Date of the analysis** (green coffee changes over time).
- ☐ **Photos** of the green coffee with the lot reference visible.

04 Samples

- ☐ **Which sample types** are offered: type, offer, pre-shipment, arrival.
- ☐ **Sample size, cost and courier**, and who pays.
- ☐ **Dispatch time** and tracking.
- ☐ **Pre-shipment approval**: does shipment depend on your written approval?
- ☐ **Retained samples**: who keeps a reference sample, and for how long?

05 Quantity and packaging

- ☐ **Number of bags, bag weight and total net weight** (Ethiopian green coffee is commonly packed in 60 kg bags).
- ☐ **Bag type**: jute only, or with hermetic liners, and the effect on price and lead time.
- ☐ **Container or part-container** options for your volume.
- ☐ **Marks on the bags** and any buyer-specific labelling.

06 Price and terms

- ☐ **Price, currency and unit** (per kg or per lb).
- ☐ **Incoterm and named port** (for example FOB Djibouti or CIF your port).
- ☐ **Offer validity** and the shipment window.
- ☐ **Payment terms** (for example cash against documents or letter of credit).
- ☐ **What happens** if the coffee is delayed or does not match the approved sample.

07 Documents and compliance

- ☐ **Documents supplied**: commercial invoice, packing list, bill of lading, certificate of origin, phytosanitary certificate, weight and quality certificates.
- ☐ **Your market's import rules** (for example FDA registration and prior notice in the US; food labelling rules for roasted coffee).
- ☐ **EU buyers**: what due-diligence information the exporter can provide under the EU Deforestation Regulation. Geolocation data is part of it, not all of it.
- ☐ **Certifications** (organic, Fairtrade...): certificate holder, scope and validity dates.

08 Roasted coffee only

- ☐ **Roast level, whole bean or ground, pack sizes and materials** (valve, nitrogen flushing).
- ☐ **Roast date, batch coding** and roast-to-dispatch time.
- ☐ **Supplier's stated shelf life** and storage guidance.
- ☐ **Labelling** languages and content required in your market.

Quick record for each offer

LOT REFERENCE	SELLER	GRADE / PROCESS	PRICE & INCOTERM	SAMPLE APPROVED?

Want this done for you?

Ethiopian Coffee Sourcing works with a network of Ethiopian exporters we know and trust. Send us a short brief and we'll gather these answers, arrange samples and bring you a clear written offer, with one point of contact from first sample to shipment.

Email: hello@ethiopiancoffeesourcing.com · **WhatsApp:** +47 973 44 353

Sources: International Coffee Organization, Resolution 420 (moisture guidance); Specialty Coffee Association, Coffee Value Assessment (2024); ICC Incoterms® 2020; European Commission guidance on the EU Deforestation Regulation. General guidance only, not legal advice.